

GENTLEMEN, YOU CAN'T FIGHT IN HERE. THIS IS THE WAR ROOM!

DR. STRANGELOVE / 1964

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Black comedy

DIRECTOR

Stanley Kubrick

WRITERS

Stanley Kubrick, Terry Southern (screenplay); Peter George (novel)

STARS

Peter Sellers, George C. Scott, Sterling Hayden, Slim Pickens

BEFORE

1957 In Kubrick's *Paths of Glory*, a World War I officer defends his men from false charges.

1962 *Lolita* is Kubrick's first collaboration with Peter Sellers.

AFTER

1987 The military's absurdities are again targeted by Kubrick in *Full Metal Jacket*.

In 1963, Stanley Kubrick decided to make a movie about the Cold War, which was heating up at the time. The West and its enemies in the Eastern Bloc had been locked in a staring contest for almost two decades, and the superpowers were getting twitchy; if either side blinked, everybody died in a thermonuclear holocaust. This was the basis of “mutually assured destruction,” the military strategy for peace that was beginning to sound like a grim promise of oblivion. The Cuban Missile Crisis had been averted a year before, but only just—surely the apocalypse was coming?

Cold War satire

When *Dr. Strangelove* opened to an unsuspecting public in January 1964, Kubrick invited audiences to see this doomsday scenario played

out on the big screen—and he expected them to laugh. Originally, the filmmaker had intended to produce a straight thriller based on *Red Alert*, Peter George's 1958 novel about a US Air Force officer who goes crazy and orders his planes to attack Russia. But, as he worked on the screenplay with writer Terry Southern, Kubrick found the politics of modern warfare too absurd for drama; he felt that the only sane way to get across the insanity of accidental self-destruction was a farce.

In Kubrick and Southern's screenplay, the plot of *Red Alert* is given a nightmarish comic spin. The novel's madman becomes Jack D. Ripper (Sterling Hayden), an American general who blames his sexual impotence on a communist plot to poison the water

“Gee, I wish we had one of those **Doomsday Machines**.”

General Turgidson / Dr. Strangelove

